learn their first trading skills through apprenticeships.[51] Shivnarain Birla (1838–1910), for instance, set forth from his village of Pilani for Bombay in 1858. It took him a twenty-day camel ride to reach Ahmedabad, the nearest railway station, and then a train to Bombay. Child marriage was a common practice, which meant that when these men left they would already be married and their wives would be left behind. Agents and sub-agents would settle in villages, live austerely and remit money back to their birthplace. In the 19th century, Shekhawati migration had increased considerably while remittances facilitated the building of community wells, local temples and now famous grand havelis. Marwari migration in the 19th century represented the Great Indian Migration Wave of capital, accompanying the labour routes towards mill towns and plantations as far as Assam and Burma.

At the turn of the 20th century, there were around 15,000 Marwaris in Calcutta, working almost exclusively in the Burrabazaar, as large firm owners, brokers and speculators in the cloth and jute trade.[52] There were over 10,000 Marwaris in Bombay, clustered around Bhuleshwar and Crawford Market. Hyderabad in the south was home to several thousand Marwaris who had first come as jewel and shawl merchants in the early 19th century. Madras and Rangoon hosted 500 Marwaris each while another 10,000 were distributed across the fourteen districts of Assam. But the biggest concentration of Marwaris was in the region that is present-day Maharashtra. As many as 60,000 Marwaris worked as traders and moneylenders here. It was here that the first major violent uprising of peasants against moneylenders would occur in the form of the Deccan Riots of 1875 in the districts of Poona and Ahmednagar.[53] High interest rates and strict discipline enforced in repayment were the reason to spark off protests. Similar protests against Marwaris in Bengal and Assam in the late 19th century would cast a negative image on the community that took time to shake off. Bengali nationalist P.C. Ray, in fact, would go to the extent of calling the Marwaris ‘parasites’ who were draining the wealth from Bengal, much like the British.[54] Perhaps spooked by such views, in the early 20th century, Marwari engagement in the public sphere grew through charity,